

You breathe air in through a tube called the windpipe, or trachea.

Air enters the lungs through two large tubes called the bronchi. Each bronchus divides into smaller and smaller tubes ending in tiny sacs called alveoli.

Your ribs form a cage. They protect your lungs.

Mucus

Dirt

Tiny "hairs" trap dirt.

Special cells

Little "brushes" help to push dirt out of your body.

Wall of the bronchus

Hot air

The air that you breathe out is warm and has water in it. You can see this if you breathe onto a mirror. The water in your breath cools down and forms a mist as it hits the cold mirror. If you touch the mirror you can feel the moisture. You can also see the water misting up when you breathe out on a cold day.



Breathe in

A powerful muscle called the diaphragm helps you breathe air into both your lungs. When this muscle is pulled tight, it moves downward, leaving more space for the lungs. As the lungs spread out to fill this larger space, they suck in air.



Breathe out

When your diaphragm relaxes, it moves back up again and squashes your lungs. There is no longer enough space in your lungs for all the air, so it is squeezed up your windpipe and out of your nose or mouth.

Sneezing

A sudden rush of built-up air blows dust or germs from your nose.

Coughing

Dust or germs in the tubes of your lungs are forced out quickly.

Laughing

The diaphragm jerks, forcing air up through your voice box and windpipe.

